Questions for Mom, Her Bank, Her Insurance Company and a Professional as You Get Her Finances Organized

Fifteen questions, sorted by who can answer them, with room to write what they say.

Some of what you're looking for is in Mom's head, some is in a bank's records, and some depends on rules that only a professional who knows your state can speak to. This guide sorts the questions by who can answer them.

It doesn't answer the questions and doesn't say which matters most. Ask them as they are, when the moment suits, and write the answer under each one.

Mom

It's her information. Ask a few at a time, and take “I'd rather not say” as an answer.

1. Who looks after the bills and the accounts now? Is it all you, or does anyone help?

2. What comes in each month, and where does it come from: Social Security, a pension, anything else?

3. Where do you have accounts and policies, and is there an older one anywhere that we might not think of?

4. Where do you keep the statements, the policies, the deed and the tax returns, and who would you want to know where they are?

Her bank, credit union or investment company

Mom asks these herself, or you ask them together, with her there.

1. Can you give me a list of every account I have with you, including any CDs?

2. How is each account titled: in my name alone, jointly with someone, or another way?

3. Who is named as beneficiary on each account, if anyone, and can I have that in writing?

4. How do I get copies of my recent statements?

Her insurance company or agent

The same way: Mom asks, or you ask with her.

1. Which policies do I have with you: life insurance, an annuity, long-term care insurance?

2. Who is listed as the owner and as the beneficiary of each one?

3. Can you send me a current copy of each policy and its most recent statement?

Your Medicaid planner

Someone who can review the inventory your family puts together. These questions depend on rules that vary by state.

1. Looking at our list, what financial information do we still need to gather, and which assets, income, insurance and property need to be included?

2. How would we find out how much Mom actually has available to pay for care, if she ever needs it?

3. We've noted how each account and property is titled and who the beneficiaries are. Which of those would you want to confirm or look at further?

An elder law attorney

Legal questions and legal documents belong to an attorney.

1. We have a question about how the house or an account is titled, or about a beneficiary. Is that one for you, and what should we bring?

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer these questions, rank them, or say what any answer means for Medicaid. If an answer raises the idea of changing an account, a title or a beneficiary, write that down as one more question for a professional. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You have your questions, and soon some answers. The planning interview gives those answers somewhere to go: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

A few of the questions for Mom follow ones AARP suggests asking when a family organizes a parent's financial records. The rest come from the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's working list for this step, and the grouping by role is ours.

1. AARP, 5 Steps to Organize Your Loved One's Financial Records